Set in the midst of warming relations, authorities in Bonn discovered that Günter Guillaume – one of Willy Brandt's intimate advisers and personal assistant – was, in fact, spying for the East German Stasi.

The bizarre sequence of events, which ended with Guillaume's widely publicised arrest, had begun decades earlier. In a case of straightforward espionage, Guillaume had been dispatched by the Stasi to the FRG in 1956 as a sleeper agent. The pace was sedate. He joined the SPD in Frankfurt and began working his way up the party ranks and by 1969 when Brandt was appointed Chancellor; the young spy – reserved, cool and a good organiser – was awarded responsibility for government liaison with the labour unions.

While Guillaume betrayed every secret that passed across his desk, he was unable to provide any really sensitive information. Nevertheless, the scandal was enough for Brandt to bite the bullet for negligence. At 23.34 on 6 May, radio and television stations across West Germany interrupted programmes to make a brief announcement. 'According to our Bonn studio, Federal Chancellor Willy Brandt has tendered his resignation. Our Bonn correspondent adds that Brandt accepted full responsibility for acts of negligence in connection with the Guillaume spy case. That is the end of the news'.7

The resignation topped-off a torrid period that had seen Brandt's chancellorship face currency turbulence, rocketing inflation, record unemployment, industrial strikes and a slump in the economy. Detractors also charged his 'Ostpolitik', too, had fallen short of expectations, and even party colleagues expressed sharp criticism of his leadership style.

Though tangled and dangerous, the Guillaume incident also embarrassed the GDR, prompting Honecker to wash his hands of any blame. In 1991, he attributed the stupidity of Markus Wolf for the debacle, saying he 'did not have the courage to inform me in time that a traitor to Brandt, Guillaume, was sitting close to him'. How much of the affair Honecker knew about is impossible to tell, but it is known he lost patience with the Stasi, and avoided reading MfS intelligence reports, which, he thought, contained the same 'gloom-and-doom information' as Bild, the West German tabloid known for its pungent celebrity coverage.8